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Education

Harvard University
Ph.D. Business Economics, 2021 to 2027 (expected)
M.A. Business Economics, 2023
University of Michigan
B.S. Statistics and Data Science (Highest Distinction), 2017

Fields

Household Finance, Corporate Finance, Public Economics

References

Adi Sunderam
Harvard Business School
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Andrei Shleifer
Harvard University
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John Y. Campbell
Harvard University
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Samuel Hanson
Harvard Business School
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Nathaniel Hendren
Massachusetts Institute of Technology
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Fellowships & Awards

NBER Graduate Student Fellowship on Consumer Financial Management, 2025-2027
NYU-Schmidt Futures Computational Economics Fellowship, 2019
CFPB Team Achievement Award, 2019
Outstanding Undergraduate in Statistics (one of top four graduates in class), 2017
Phi Beta Kappa (junior year), 2017
Harry S. Truman Scholarship Finalist, 2016

Teaching

Corporate Finance and Banking (Harvard PhD, 2023, Samuel Hanson and Adi Sunderam)
Big Data Tools for Data Management and Acquisition (Michigan BBA, 2017, Hila Etzion)

Employment

Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Director's Financial Analyst, 2017-2019
Applied Predictive Technologies (acquired by Mastercard), Product Management Intern, 2016

Research

Research Assistant, Harvard University, John Y. Campbell, 2022-2024
Research Assistant, Harvard University, Raj Chetty and Ed Glaeser, 2022
Junior Research Scientist, NYU Stern, Theresa Kuchler and Johannes Stroebel, 2019-2021
Contractor, Facebook Core Data Science Team, 2019-2021

Job Market Paper

The Supply Side of Consumer Debt Repayment (with Justin Katz and Claire Shi)

We study how lender responses to consumer biases affect credit card debt. Using account-level credit bureau data, we document a new fact: many consumers make near-minimum credit card repayments while also overpaying lower-interest installment debt. We estimate an empirical model

in which lenders optimally set minimum payments given this behavior. Because some liquid consumers make near-minimum payments, lenders lower minimums to slow repayment, increasing high-interest debt balances and interest revenue. Our model implies that this lender response increases revolving debt by between $35 and $48 billion. This finding illustrates how optimizing lenders can amplify the effects of consumer biases in equilibrium.

Publications

The Social Integration of International Migrants: Evidence from the Networks of Syrians in Germany (with Michael Bailey, Drew Johnston, Martin Koenen, Theresa Kuchler, and Johannes Stroebel), *Journal of Political Economy*, 2026.

Social Networks Shape Beliefs and Behavior: Evidence from Social Distancing during the COVID-19 Pandemic (with Michael Bailey, Drew Johnston, Martin Koenen, Theresa Kuchler, and Johannes Stroebel), *Journal of Political Economy Microeconomics*, 2024.

JUE Insight: The geographic spread of COVID-19 correlates with the structure of social networks as measured by Facebook (with Theresa Kuchler and Johannes Stroebel), *Journal of Urban Economics,* 2022.

The Determinants of Social Connectedness in Europe (with Michael Bailey, Drew Johnston, Theresa Kuchler, Bogdan State, and Johannes Stroebel), *Social Informatics*, 2020.

Working Papers

Revenue-Based Financing (with Claire Shi and Rowan Clarke), *R&R at Review of Financial Studies*

We study revenue-based financing, an emerging capital source for small firms in low- and middle-income countries. Using transaction-level data from a South African payment platform, we show firms that take financing process 16% less revenue through the platform than observably similar non-takers after eight months, slowing repayment. Two natural experiments show this reflects moral hazard from firms diverting revenue and adverse selection. Repayment improves when firms use the platform's other services (e.g., inventory management tools), and screening improves with longer histories and repeat financing. Our results highlight the frictions with flexible repayment models in developing economies, and how providers mitigate them.

Who Borrows on Credit Cards? The Economic and Social Determinants of Consumer Debt (with Trevor J. Bakker and Claire Shi)

Using linked credit bureau and Census data, we show that revolving credit card debt is highly persistent, insensitive to income growth, and negatively predicts future earnings. Standard rational or behavioral consumption-smoothing models cannot generate these facts without heterogeneous types. We study the sources of this heterogeneity and show that it is shaped in part by the behavior of one's parents. Exploiting variation in the age of children at parental separation, we document a causal effect of parental exposure. Parents transmit specific repayment behaviors, such as overpaying installment debt while revolving credit card debt, as well as broader cultural attitudes from their country of origin. Our findings suggest that learned norms are an important determinant of consumer debt outcomes.

Gambling for Goals (with Costas Arkolakis, Spencer Y. Kwon, Claire Shi, and Hyunjoo Yang)

Young adults in advanced economies have grown more pessimistic about their economic prospects in recent years. At the same time, gambling-like financial activities have proliferated. We link these trends through a Friedman-Savage (1948) motive: when life goals such as homeownership or marriage seem out of reach, individuals turn to financial gambles. We test this theory using an original survey combined with millions of linked records from Korea's leading credit bureau, telecom provider, and credit card issuer. Consistent with the theory, individuals who place greater importance on hard-to-reach goals are more likely to exhibit risk-seeking preferences and make riskier investments. Within-individuals, cryptocurrency app usage rises during unemployment and falls after winning the right to purchase price-regulated housing through a lottery. A calibration

shows how hard-to-reach goals lead households to act more aggressively on their beliefs, amplifying the consequences of overoptimism.

Behavioral Cross-Selling: Evidence from Retail Credit Cards (with Sarah E. Robinson and Claire Shi)

Why do some non-financial firms rely on revenue from consumer financial products? At several large U.S. retailers, direct revenues from credit card partnerships exceed total operating income. This paper proposes a theory of behavioral cross-selling, in which firms use their access to customers to cross-sell products that capitalize on behavioral biases, such as inattention or forgetfulness. We test our theory in the retail credit card market using data from a major credit bureau. Although retail cards account for only 17% of balances in our sample, they generate 45% of missed minimum payments, triggering late fees. Liquidity constraints cannot fully explain missed minimums: among individuals with multiple cards, nearly half of missed payments on retail cards could have been avoided by reallocating excess payments from other cards. Consistent with the theory, firms in locations with more avoidable missed payments are more likely to offer retail cards and provide larger sign-up incentives. We discuss how behavioral cross-selling can help explain practices in industries such as airlines, auto dealerships, tax preparation services, and sports entertainment.

Seminars & Conferences

Opportunity Insights (2025); Midwestern Finance Association (2024); Urban Economics Association European Meetings (2023); LACEA HUMANS Seminar (2023); Venice Summer Institute (2022); International Conference on Social Informatics (2020); Data Science Conference on COVID-19 (2020)

Academic Service

Referee: *American Economic Review, Quarterly Journal of Economics, AER: Insights, Review of Economics and Statistics, Regional Science and Urban Economics, Economic Inquiry*
Co-Organizer: Harvard Doctoral Finance Workshop (2023-24), Finance Reading Group (2022-23)
Co-Organizer: Pre-Doctoral Research in Economics Workshop (2021)
Tax Preparer for Volunteer Income Tax Assistance Program (2018)

Research Grants

Innovations for Poverty Action: Digital Payments and Credit for Firms, 2025* ($50,000)
South African Reserve Bank: FinTech and Small Firms, 2024* ($10,000)
USAID Development Innovation Ventures, 2024* ($450,000; received $200,000 pre-shutdown)
Chae Family Economics Research Fund, 2023 ($20,000)
(* = Co-PI)

Software Skills

R, Python, Stata, SQL, Fortran